

HIGH SCHOOLS

St. Ignatius rolls into final 8; Brunswick bows out

By JACK McDERMOTT

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

TOLEDO — The smile on the face of St. Ignatius coach Brian Becker said it all following last night's Division I, 67-53, regional semifinal victory over Toledo Central Catholic.

BOYS BASKETBALL

At Toledo

out of Ireland, and what a better way for a pair of Irishmen to celebrate the day than by beating the Irish."

Becker and fellow Irishman T.J. McHugh were in top form, as the Wildcats battled back from a

22-17 first-quarter deficit for a 14-point win.

The Wildcats move on to a Division I regional championship against Mansfield on Saturday at 7:30 p.m. The winner of that game heads to Columbus for the state semifinals. Mansfield (21-3) was a 67-41 winner over Brunswick in last night's first game.

St. Ignatius entered the fourth quarter with a 51-47 lead. Then McHugh, a 6-8 senior, put the icing on the celebration with 10 points, giving him a game-high 25.

"We got off to a slow start," Becker said, "but defensively we got better and better as the game progressed."

"A lot of our success tonight

came from hitting our open man, and a lot of the credit for that belongs to Tony DeCesare. He did one fantastic job of finding the open man the whole night, and that is what kept our offense going."

For the night, the Wildcats (18-7) connected on 26-of-54 attempts from the field for 48 percent. They held the Irish to 36 percent on 19-of-53 shooting.

"I told my kids at the half that we needed to step up our effort on Lamarr Cheers," Becker said. "He scored 13 against us in the first half, but he finished with 17, so I guess we accomplished what we needed to do against him."

Kelly Hunt led the Irish with 19 points. Rahsaan Benton, a 6-1

sophomore, chipped in with 12 points for the Wildcats to support McHugh's effort.

Mansfield 67, Brunswick 41 — Brunswick held a 14-4 lead with 2:01 remaining in the first quarter last night after a 3-pointer by junior Mike Mifflin.

However, the Tigers ran off 11 unanswered points to take a 15-14 lead with 6:37 remaining in the first half. Then they pulled out to a 29-22 lead at the intermission, thanks to a 15-point second quarter by Marquis Sykes, who led all scorers with 28 points.

Brunswick wasn't ready to be counted out just yet.

The Blue Devils ran off the first nine points of the third

quarter to take a 31-29 lead with 4:06 left in the period on a basket by 6-3 junior Eric Reminder. Mixon then closed out the third quarter with a basket from the top of the key, giving the Blue Devils a 37-34 lead entering the final eight minutes of play.

Mansfield, which had scored 34 points in the first three periods, then outscored Brunswick, 33-4, in the fourth quarter to win going away.

"I told my kids coming in that the key for us would be our ability to handle their pressure," said Brunswick coach Joe Mackey.

"And at the start of the fourth quarter, I felt that we were going to hang on."

"We'd done a poor job of han-

dling pressure in the first half," Mackey continued. "And for most of the third quarter, I was very pleased with what I saw. I felt comfortable going into the fourth quarter with the lead, then we started to struggle, and once they got going, we just didn't answer."

Sykes, who had scored two points in the first quarter and a 3-pointer in the third, led the Tigers' charge in the fourth quarter with eight points. Fellow seniors Rod Burton and Jeremee Butts added seven points each to the drive.

Brunswick, which finished 13-12, was making its first regional appearance in school history. The Blue Devils were led by Mixon with 15 points.

Quicker picker-upper

Benedictine looks to Chris Leanza to provide some high-grade fuel

By EDDIE DWYER

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Throughout his 12 seasons as varsity basketball coach at his alma mater, Benedictine's Frank Novak has been involved in many big games.

But the game Novak said he will take to his grave took place during last season's Division II state semifinals in St. John Arena in Columbus.

It was the day Novak's resilient floor leader, Chris Leanza, said he got "a little help from God."

"I'll never forget when he banked in that 3-point shot, referring to the 62-58 overtime victory over Hamilton Badin. "That really got us going. And then he came down and hit two more."

With the Bengals trailing, 40-31, with 6:28 remaining in regulation, Leanza hit a 3-pointer high off the glass. It was a shot that spurred another dramatic finish for the two-time defending state champions.

As Novak so vividly recalled, Leanza hit two more clutch shots from beyond the arc, one that enabled Benedictine to close to 41-40 and another that tied the score at 45 with 2:54 left in regulation. After a frustrating first half, Leanza scored all 17 of his points in the third and fourth quarters, including four 3-pointers.

"I needed to pick up my game," Leanza said. "Heck, my teammates were doing a great job, and they didn't deserve me playing bad. I had to pick it up for them."

A three-time All-Northeast Lakes District selection and the catalyst in the Bengals' postseason prominence, Leanza has adapted to his role as the player Novak relies on to pick things up.

Possessing a work ethic he said was instilled by his parents, Anthony and Joanne, Leanza has a presence on the court that is vital to everything Novak and his staff attempt to accomplish.

"He's the coach on the floor," Novak said of his 6-0 senior point guard. "Even if we don't make the right call, Chris will. His knowledge of the game is uncanny. We definitely lose something when he's not on the floor."

For the last four years, there have been few days Leanza hasn't been on a basketball court.

A resident of Parma, Leanza awakes at 5 a.m. every school day, makes the 45-minute drive to the East Side and arrives at Benedictine more than an hour before school begins. It is during that early morning hour that the Bengals' third all-time leading scorer hones his skills in an empty gymnasium in the Trueman Memorial Fieldhouse.

"During my freshman year, I started the season on the junior-varsity team," Leanza said. "I wanted to play on the varsity, so I did everything I could to make it possible."

Leanza's early morning ritual led to him being promoted to the varsity his freshman season and still is a factor in his success.

An Associated Press All-Ohio honoree, Leanza has more than 1,140 career points and is averaging more than 17 points this season. But as impressive as those numbers are, they only begin to describe the game Leanza brings to the court.

"The first thing I noticed was his ability to shoot the ball," Novak said. "Chris could always shoot. But it didn't end there. He is a



MIKE LEVY/PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Benedictine senior point guard Chris Leanza takes time to work on his game each morning before school. The senior will lead the Bengals against Copley tonight in a regional semifinal in the Canton Memorial Civic Center.

THE LEANZA FILE

Name: Chris Leanza.

Age: 18. School: Benedictine.

Year: Senior. Sport: Basketball.

Background: The four-year varsity player and three-year starter is third on the Bengals' all-time scoring list with more than 1,140 points. His averages of 17.1 points, 4.2 assists and 2.3 steals have led Benedictine to another regional appearance in Division II. The Bengals (18-6) are attempting to become the third Ohio team to capture three consecutive boys state basketball championships, joining Dayton Stivers and Columbus Wehrle. Leanza, who carries a 4.3 grade-point average, will further his education and basketball career at Yale. He also considered Princeton and the University of Akron.

complete player who can rebound, defend and pass. And he has worked extremely hard on improving his strength, which you need in order to play at the next level."

For Leanza, the next level will be at Yale. His 4.3 grade-point average and athletic skills have earned him the chance to play college basketball and receive an Ivy

League education in the process. A member of Student Council and the National Honor Society, Leanza's numbers in the classroom already have drawn the interest of a major Wall Street business firm, which has contacted him about a possible internship.

"He's a special young man, getting it done in the classroom like he has," Novak said. "But then the guys who make it to the top, they put in the time."

The top for Leanza and his teammates would be a third consecutive Division II state championship. And if the Bengals do join Dayton Stivers (1928-30) and Columbus Wehrle (1988-90) as the only Ohio teams to win three straight boys titles, you can be sure Leanza will be a major contributor.

"I have done my share of scoring on this team," said Leanza, who scored a career-high 43 points against Euclid last season. "But I don't think that's my main contribution. I like to try to get everybody involved. "A third straight title would be the biggest feat in our lives right now. But everybody has to put the team first. It's happened before, and I know we can do it again. Just as long as we stay unselfish."

Late scoring drought fells Olmsted Falls

By BOB MIGRA

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

BOWLING GREEN — Columbus Beechcroft coach Joe Dudas said basketball can be a very simple game.

And last night the Cougars kept it simple in a 69-58 victory over Olmsted Falls (21-3) in the Division II regional semifinals in Bowling Green State University's Anderson Arena.

Beechcroft came back from a slow start to dominate the game at both ends of the floor in the fourth quarter.

"We really didn't change anything," Dudas said. "The only adjustment we made was to get back on defense. When you execute and you have guys like DeLano [Thomas] and Damien [Lee] shooting the ball, you can do a lot."

Thomas scored 20 points, blocked eight shots and pulled down 11 rebounds to lead Beechcroft (19-4) to tomorrow's championship game against Lima Shawnee (19-6).

Lee scored 17 points to help Beechcroft to its first regional victory.

Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said it was simply a matter of the Cougars' superior physical ability taking over at the end.

"They're just better athletes than we are," Donahue said. "There aren't many teams that play team basketball better than we do. But in the second half, they got us out of our game and into their game."

The Bulldogs, making their sixth regional appearance in the 1990s, held the lead for three-plus quarters. Lee's 3-point goal with 6:20 left gave Beechcroft a 54-51 lead. It would never trail again.

Manzie Williams' outside shooting and Mike Gansey's inside play kept the Bulldogs in control in the first half. Williams led all scorers with 21 points. Gansey scored 19 points and had nine rebounds.

Williams started the game with two consecutive 3-point goals. His third 3-pointer, with 5:15 left in the first quarter, gave Olmsted Falls an 11-2 lead.

Williams finished the first half with five 3-point goals and 17 points. But he would be held to four second-half points.

"They did a real nice job on Manzie Williams in the second half, denying him the ball," Donahue said.

Beechcroft held Olmsted Falls to three field goals in 12 attempts in the fourth quarter.

"It's been that way for us all year," Dudas said. "When we want to play defense, we play defense. Simple as that."

Lima Shawnee 59, Shelby 50 — Shawnee overcame a flurry of Shelby 3-point goals in the third quarter to advance to Saturday's championship game with a come-from-behind victory.

Shelby made five 3-point goals in the third quarter to take a 40-37 lead. Two layups by Josh Steele to start the fourth quarter extended Shelby's lead, 44-37.

Shawnee then went on a 13-2 run to take the lead. Then it made 9 of 10 foul shots in the final two minutes to pull away. Mike Marshall led the Indians with 23 points.

"It was a real game of runs," Shawnee coach Jeff Heistan said. "They hit some incredible threes to get right back in the game. And I thought our kids did a fabulous job of not cracking at a critical time in the game."

Rams roll snake eyes as tourney run ends

By E.L. ROGERS

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

There's only so much time you can spend in Vegas.

Only so many times the dealer calls your number.

"It seemed like the dice just didn't fall our way tonight," Akron Garfield player Dontell Lewis said. "We rolled the dice, but things just didn't work out."

Garfield had planned on running the table at the Division I regionals, but the Rams ran into bad luck last night at the University of Akron and lost to Youngstown Rayen, 71-55.

"Hey, I'm overjoyed that we made it this far, because there are a lot of other teams out there that wish they could have been here," said Lewis, who scored nine points. "We were David, and the words everybody was throwing out there was Goliath. We were the little man, ready to slay everything."

"The team looked to me for leadership, and I feel like I let my teammates down. If I had to do it all over again, I'd put my life out there to win this game for my teammates."

Garfield (12-12) made a magical run through its sectional, knocking off Wadsworth, Central-Hower, Hudson and Cuyahoga Falls to capture the program's first district title since 1990. Most had picked the Rams to fall in the first round.

So, here was Garfield. On a roll. Taking money by the truckload from the postseason casino. Dealer, more money on the same number, please.

Enter Rayen (19-5). The Tigers stepped to the table with a barrel of talent, including Northeast Ohio player of the year Romuald Augustin, a 6-7 senior swingman who has attracted the likes of Toledo, Notre Dame and Providence. Augustin scored 19 points.

"He was good, but he wasn't all that," Garfield guard Laurence Chery said.

Said Augustin: "I definitely felt

YOUNGSTOWN RAYEN 71

AKRON GARFIELD 55

like I was a walking target. I was getting a lot of triple-teams, and there were times when a lot of people were coming at me before I even got the ball."

The last thing Garfield wanted to do was play a fast-paced game, but that's what happened. That led to five Rayen players scoring in double figures.

"I thought Rayen was a good team with a lot of good athletes," Garfield coach Jerry Laria said. "We just got into their style of play, a running game, and that tempo wasn't to our liking. Maybe our kids got too keyed up."

Garfield opened the game with a layup from Andre Vaughn, but Rayen answered that with six straight points. Rayen stretched its lead to 9-4, but the Rams cut that to 13-11 with 35 seconds left in the quarter on a layup by Chery.

Rayen's lead swelled to 26-16 and 33-18 during the second period. The Tigers took a 37-20 lead with 1:35 left in the half and led, 37-25, at intermission.

"We were really concerned about stopping their shooters," Rayen guard Larry Scroggins said. "Their one guy, Matt Kersten, was hurting us. We'd follow him around on the court, but he still got his points. With all the crowd noise, some of the players probably couldn't hear when we were trying to talk to each other on defense."

Kersten (20 points) made 6 of 9 3-pointers, and he's one of the biggest reasons Garfield rallied. By the end of the third quarter, the Rams had cut the lead to 46-37.

"They just kept coming at us," said Rayen coach Phillip House, whose team outrebounded Garfield, 45-35.

With seven minutes left, Kersten sank a 3-pointer from the right wing to cut Rayen's lead to 48-40. The Rams had a chance to gnaw into that lead throughout the fourth, but they turned the ball over at key moments.

BY THE NUMBERS

BOYS BASKETBALL

REGIONAL SEMIFINALS	
Division I	
St. Ignatius 67, Toledo Cent. Cath. 53	
Mansfield 67, Brunswick 41	
Youngstown Rayen 71, Akron Garfield 55	
East Liverpool 71, Hilliard Darby 43	
Division II	
Struthers 41, Troy 39	
Columbus Beechcroft 69, Olmsted Falls 58	
Lima Shawnee 59, Shelby 50	
Cincinnati McKinley 84, Columbus Whitwell 59	
Kettering Alter 74, Kings Mills 69, OT	
Phid 62, Portsmouth 59	
Washington Court House 39, Dresden Tri-Valley 37	

SUMMARIES

Division I	
At University of Toledo	
Mansfield 67, Brunswick 41	8 21 5 33-67
Mansfield: Hillard 2, Burton 7, Sykes 28, Thompson 2, Budd 7, Davis 4, Minard 10, Huggins 3, Hoots 2, Bradley 2	
Brunswick: Mixon 15, Herman 12, Marenc 5, Heaver 2, Ruman 5, Wray 2	
Division II	
At University of Akron	
Youngstown Rayen 71, Akron Garfield 55	13 24 9 25-71
Youngstown Rayen: Taver 2, Augustin 19, Walters 10, Scroggins 12, Stewart 10, Sanders 2, Anderson 18	

Akron Garfield: Vaughn 2, Lewis 9, Starks 2, Cherry 7, Kersten 20, Moss 2, McKee 13.

Division II

At Bowling Green State University

Olmsted Falls 19 17 13 9-58

Col. Beechcroft 10 18 19 22-69

Olmsted Falls: Mucha 2, Koch 3, M.W. Williams 21, Gansey 19, B. Williams 2, Radigan 8, Schneider 2.

Columbus Beechcroft: Cox 13, Thomas 20, Woods 13, Lee 17, Jones 8.

Shelby 11 11 18 10-59

Lima Shawnee 6 20 11 22-59

Shelby: Stepien 8, Albert 11, Hanesy 5, Lantz 11, Fritz 3, Steele 12.

Lima Shawnee: Powell 11, Siesel 10, Dawson 10, LaBaume 5, Marshall 23.

In Canton Memorial Civic Center

Struthers 10 13 10 8-41

Trway 6 10 10 8-39

Struthers: Sepsey 2, Grandy 3, McFadden 25, Salarek 2, Scott 6, Becker 3.

Trway: Sanderson 4, Luntan 6, Starr 7, Miller 8, Garrison 4, Tucker 4, Scottzdale 5.

In Columbus Fairgrounds Coliseum

Yesterday: East Liverpool 71, Hillard Darby 43

Today: Grove City (21-3) vs. Springfield Valley 23

Saturday: Championship — East Liverpool 22-1

At Wright State University

Today: Cincinnati Moller (17-6) vs. Troy (20-2), 6:15; Cincinnati Whitrow (18-4) vs. Beavercreek (24-0), 8.

Saturday: Championship, 7:30.

Division II

In Canton Memorial Civic Center

Yesterday: Struthers 41, Trway 39

Today: Copley (17-5) vs. Benedictine (18-6), 7

Saturday: Championship — Struthers (22-2) vs. Copley/Benedictine winner, 7:30.

At Bowling Green State University

Yesterday: Lima Shawnee 59, Shelby 50; Columbus Beechcroft 69, Olmsted Falls 58

Saturday: Championship — Lima Shawnee (15-6) vs. Columbus Beechcroft (12-14), 7:30.

In Ohio University

Yesterday: Philo 62, Portsmouth 54; Washington Court House 39, Dresden Tri-Valley 37

Saturday: Championship — Philo (21-3) vs. Washington Court House (17-7), 7:30.

At Wright State University

Yesterday: Cn. McKinley 84, Columbus Whitwell 59; Kettering Alter 74, Kings Mills 69

Saturday: Championship — Cincinnati McKinley (20-5) vs. Kettering Alter (18-6), 3.

At Ohio University

Convocation Center

Today: Fort Frye (22-2) vs. Eastern Brown (19-5), 6:15; Grandview Hts. (20-3) vs. Richmond Dale SE (20-4), 8.

Saturday: Championship, 3.

At Wright State University

Today: Cincinnati Maderia (22-1) vs. Bloom-Carroll (21-1), 6:15; Cincinnati Firman (17-6) vs. Milton Union (14-10), 8.

Saturday: Championship, 1.

Division IV

In Canton Fieldhouse

Today: Kidron Central Christian 53, Kirtland 45; Berlin Hiland 78, Kirtland Heritage Christian 58

Tomorrow: Championship — Kidron Central Christian (18-5) vs. Berlin Hiland (24-1), 7:30.

At University of Toledo

Today: Edgerton 56, Pandora-Gibbs 50; Fort Jennings 60, Fremont St. Joseph 42

Saturday: Championship — Edgerton (20-4) vs. Fort Jennings (23-1), 8:15.

In Columbus Fairgrounds Coliseum

Today: Worthington Christian 53, Lucas 42; Cardington (18-5) vs. Waterford (16-7), 8.

Tomorrow: Championship — Worthington Christian (21-3) vs. Cardington (19-5), 7:30.

At Christy of Dayton Arena

Today: Fort Recovery 55, Cincinnati Seven Hills 40; Botkins 52, Houston 49

Tomorrow: Championship — Botkins (18-7) vs. Fort Recovery (23-1), 7:30.

GIRLS BASKETBALL

Regular Season

MAHET SCHOOLS

School of Arts 11 16 13 7-47

Jane Addams 7 8 28 10-48